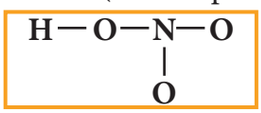
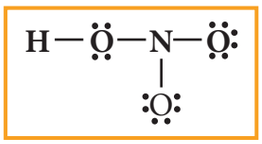
2. Total number of valence electrons in HNO_3
   = [1 × 1(hydrogen)] + [1 × 5(nitrogen)] + [3× 6(oxygen)] = 1+ 5 + 18 = 24
3. Draw single bonds between atoms. Four bonds can be drawn as shown in the figure for HNO_3 which account for eight electrons (4 bond pairs).



4. Distribute the remaining sixteen (24 - 8= 16) electrons as eight lone pairs starting from most electronegative atom, the oxygen. Six lone pairs are distributed to the two terminal oxygens (three each) to satisfy their octet and two pairs are distributed to the oxygen that is connected to hydrogen to satisfy its octet.



5. Verify weather all the atoms have octet configuration. In the above distribution, the nitrogen has one pair short for octet. Therefore, move one of the lone pair from the terminal oxygen to form another bond with nitrogen.

The Lewis structure of nitric acid is given as

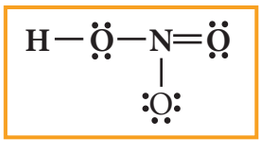
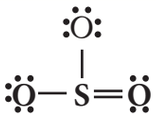
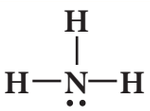
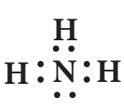
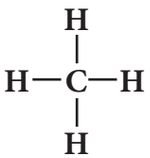
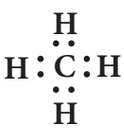
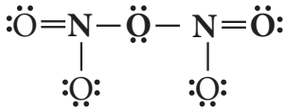


Fig 10. 6 Lewis structure of Nitric acid

Table 10.1 : The Lewis dot structures for some molecules

S. No	Molecule	Lewis Structure	
1.	Sulphur trioxide (SO_3)		
2.	Ammonia (NH_3)		
3.	Methane (CH_4)		
4.	Dinitrogen Pentoxide (N_2O_5)		

Note

It is to be noted that nearly in all their compounds, certain elements form a fixed number of bonds. For example, Fluorine forms only one bond. Hydrogen, oxygen, nitrogen and carbon atoms form one, two, three and four bonds, respectively.

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